

Competency Based Interviews

A **competency** is defined by the "ability to perform activities to the standards required in employment using an appropriate mix of knowledge, skill and attitude".

Every job specification can be described in terms of competencies. They help give you, the interviewee, the opportunity during an interview to provide structured answers to demonstrate your ability to carry out a job.

You will find some interviews can be completely competency based. Typically you will often receive prior notification of this. The company will usually make you aware of the competencies they will be exploring. These days, you may also experience a mixture of biographical interviews (talking through your career history) with some exploration of specific competencies.

Frequently explored competencies include:

Teamwork	Ownership
Communication	Problem solving
People management	Quality and accuracy
Flexibility	Analytical skills
Influencing	Pro-activity/Initiative

The interviewer will have a set of indicators to illustrate where your answer fits into their competency framework. This makes the interview process both fair and easily measurable.

During a competency based interview some interviewers may not give any reaction to your given answers. Do not be put off by this. It is simply the style used for this particular interview approach.

How to Prepare

1. Review the job description carefully and identify the skills and traits that are likely to be assessed
2. Identify the situations and experiences that you will refer to in the interview, to demonstrate these skills and traits

How to Answer

The STAR model is a helpful technique to follow when answering questions. It will help you provide structure to your answer.

Situation	describe a situation/problem you have encountered
Task	describe the task that the situation required
Action	describe the action you took and the obstacles you had to overcome
Results	highlight outcomes overcome

If you are not sure about the meaning of a question, take time to ask for clarification. It is better to do this rather than to give an unfocused answer.

Typical Questions

Here is a sample of questions you may be asked. It is good to plan examples for each section as it will help you feel prepared and focused. **Just make sure you are answering the question they are asking.**

Motivation

- Please tell me about a situation when you had to complete a particularly tedious task?
- How do you measure your own success?
- In your current role how do you know if you have done a good job?

Teamworking

- What experience have you had working in a team?
- What skills and personal qualities have you contributed to the teams you have been a part of?
- Describe a situation where conflicts have developed within a team. How did you resolve them?

Organisational skills

- Tell me about an environment you have worked in that is most conducive to your achieving results
- How do you schedule your time/set your priorities?
- Tell me about what you did last time you had a personal backlog of work?

Influencing

- Can you describe a situation where you have proactively built a successful relationship with a particular client/colleague?
- Can you tell me of a time you have tried to influence or persuade someone to do something?
- Tell me about a person or event that has been influential in your personal development

Analytical skills

- What were the steps you took in deciding to choose your degree/career/last job?
- What sort of decisions do you have to take in your current role? Of these which do you have to consult your manager on?
- When have you made a wrong decision about something? Why was that?

Communication

- Tell me about a time when you were successful in getting crucial information from another person
- Tell me about a time when someone misunderstood what you were attempting to communicate to them. How did you overcome this?

Problem solving

- Tell me about a situation where you achieved a satisfactory outcome to a problem that others couldn't solve? What did you do and what was the outcome?
- What significant problems have you faced in the last year?

Good luck and remember to check in with us if you need any further information or advice.